

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

Using the following two primary sources, construct a document-based argument that analyzes how Pearl Harbor transformed American public opinion and government policy from isolationism to total war mobilization.

US.48 — Explain the progression of key events and President Franklin D. Roosevelt’s response to world crises that lead to U.S. entry into World War II, including the Quarantine Speech, the Four Freedoms Speech, the Atlantic Charter, the Lend-Lease Act, and Pearl Harbor.

US.49 — Analyze the response of the United States to the plight of European Jews before the start of the war, the U.S. liberation of concentration camps during the war, and the immigration of Holocaust survivors after the war.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

The sources

Document A

Excerpt from President Franklin D. Roosevelt's 'Day of Infamy' address to Congress, December 8, 1941 (National Archives, public domain)

“Yesterday, December 7th, 1941 — a date which will live in infamy — the United States of America was suddenly and deliberately attacked by naval and air forces of the Empire of Japan... No matter how long it may take us to overcome this premeditated invasion, the American people in their righteous might will win through to absolute victory.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT A

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document B

Excerpt from FDR's 'Four Freedoms' speech, January 6, 1941, nearly one year before Pearl Harbor
(National Archives, public domain)

“In the future days, which we seek to make secure, we look forward to a world founded upon four essential human freedoms... The fourth is freedom from fear — which, translated into world terms, means a world-wide reduction of armaments to such a point and in such a thorough fashion that no nation will be in a position to commit an act of physical aggression against any neighbor — anywhere in the world.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT B

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The question

Using SOAPS (Speaker, Occasion, Audience, Purpose, Significance) analysis for each document and your knowledge of U.S. foreign policy, analyze how Roosevelt's rhetoric evolved from January 1941 to December 1941, and evaluate what that evolution reveals about the political and strategic factors shaping U.S. entry into World War II. Include at least two pieces of outside evidence. Address the relationship between FDR's pre-Pearl Harbor rhetoric (Document B) and the formal isolationist legal framework he was navigating.

Plan your answer

Your claim	
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Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document A		
Document B		
Outside knowledge		

Write your response

